

II. THE CITY BEAUTIFUL: MONUMENTAL URBANISM IN BEAUX-ARTS AMERICA

It would be difficult to exaggerate the effect of Haussmann's Paris on other cities of the world. It is fair to say that, even within the context of modernism and postmodernism, designers have continued to employ some of the devices of monumental urban planning, of which mid-nineteenth-century Paris remains the primary example, especially in capital cities where the building program has called for a symbolical display of government power through architecture and landscape. Even without such an agenda, modernism's imperative to enable vehicular movement and to assist the forces of capitalist industry and commerce was strong, and practically everywhere old streets were widened, fortifications gave way to new boulevards, and rail transportation systems were built as city after city was opened up both to new possibilities of urban life and to a radically new urban form.

Ironically, in democratic America the desire for civic monumentality was such that Gilded Age magnates and political leaders overlooked the authoritarianism implicit in this style of city planning, adopting

its forms to express the lofty ideals of the republic rather than the power of monarchy. It was a time when newly made American millionaires looked to Europe for role models in the mores of aristocracy. It was a time when Americans sought to emulate Europe's impressive legacy of heritage buildings and monuments in the mansions of the rich and in the public art and architecture that proclaimed the prosperity and dignity of their cities. In this they were helped by the training undertaken by design professionals. The aesthetics of several generations of American architects and landscape architects was forged in Haussmann's Paris under the influence of the *École des Beaux-Arts* where they studied beginning in the last third of the nineteenth century.

By the beginning of the twentieth century, in the wake of the 1893 Chicago World's Fair, the neoclassicism they imbibed there was being vigorously promoted by Charles Mulford Robinson, a Rochester, New York, journalist and the author of *The Improvement of Towns and Cities, or the Practical Basis of Civic Aesthetics* (1901) and *Modern Civic Art, or The City Made Beautiful* (1903). The City Beautiful movement aimed at ennobling American cities and European colonial capitals through monumental planning, and Daniel Burnham, fresh from his triumph as principal planner of the 1893 World's Columbian Fair in Chicago, was commissioned to develop new layouts for Cleveland, San Francisco, Manila, and Chicago (fig. 10.14). Where there were existing gridiron street patterns, these plans attempted to impose upon them grand diagonal boulevards whose intersections formed magnificent plazas and whose vistas terminated in monumental public works.

Frederick Law Olmsted had spent a good deal of time during his last productive years mentoring his son and namesake who became his professional heir and the future head of the firm. It is ironic in light of Olmsted, Sr.'s, antipathy toward the heroic style of the Gilded Age that one of the first commissions Olmsted, Jr., assumed upon entering practice was in collaboration with Burnham. Following the Chicago World's Fair, Senator James McMillan's Committee on the District of Columbia appointed him landscape architect on the team under Burnham's leadership to carry L'Enfant's original plan for the nation's capital to a new level of monumental grandeur. The other members were Stanford White's partner, Charles McKim (1847–1909), and the Beaux-Arts sculptor Augustus Saint-Gaudens (1848–1907).

In order to prepare themselves for this chal-



10.15. McMillan Plan for Washington, D.C. 1901

lenging assignment to give Washington, D.C., an image that not only glorified the founders of the republic and the president who saved the Union but also one that suited America's newly assumed identity as a world power, Burnham, McKim, Olmsted, and the secretary to Senator McMillan, Charles Moore, sailed for Europe in the summer of 1901 to study architecture, parks, and urban design in several cities. For seven weeks they sketched and discussed ideas stimulated by their travels to Paris, Rome, Venice, Budapest, Frankfurt, Berlin, and London.

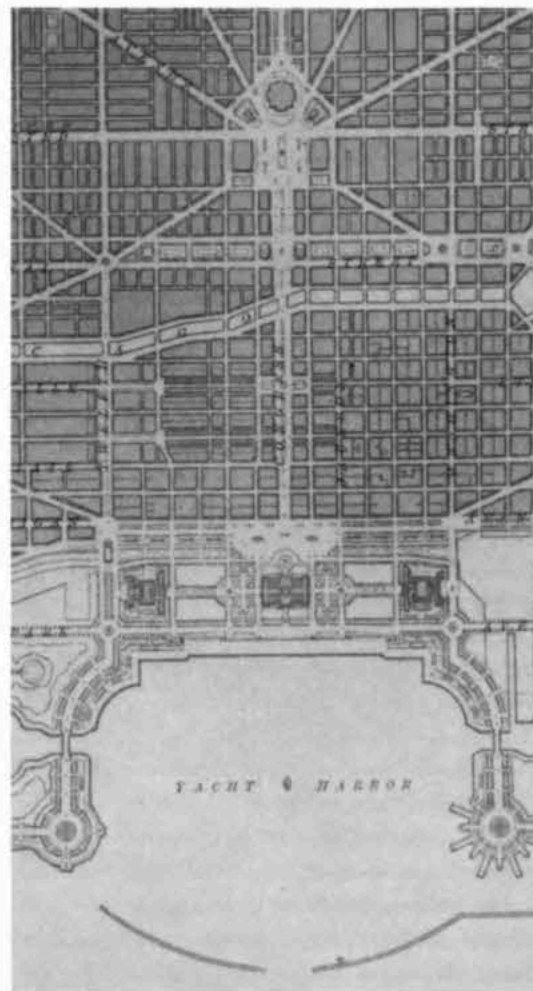
Washington's layout had become muddled by later nonconforming elements, such as a train station athwart the Mall, but the outlines of its grand plan, derived from that of Versailles, were partially realized and called for further development. Not surprisingly, the members of the team returned on the first of August determined to clarify, reinforce, and extend L'Enfant's axial plan (fig. 10.15). Within the contentious atmosphere of Washington politics, they were fortunate to win critical support from President Theodore Roosevelt and, after his election in 1909, from President William Howard Taft. Thus, congressional opponents did not manage to derail the McMillan team's intentions, and the head of the Pennsylvania Railroad acceded to its recommendation that Union Station be placed north of the Capitol. Construction of a new station according to Burnham's plans was completed in 1907, and the old train tracks were removed from the Mall once it was made operational. Adjacent to the station on the northwest a similarly monumental new Post Office, also designed by Burnham, was built. The proposal to realign the Mall on axis with the Washington Monument and plant the remainder as a simple grass *parterre* bordered by quadruple rows of elms was also carried out after much debate and furor in the press.

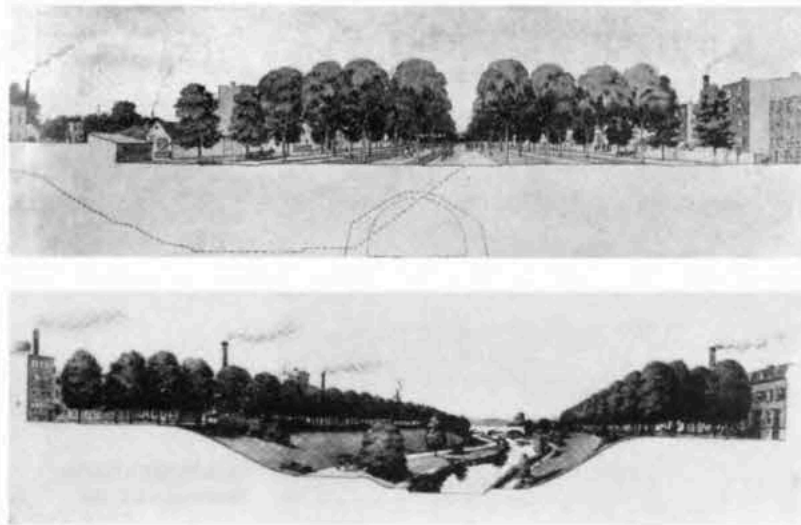
As his final act of office before leaving the presidency, Theodore Roosevelt appointed a Council of

Fine Arts composed of architects, painters, sculptors, and a landscape architect—Frederick Law Olmsted, Jr. Approved in a bill passed by the House of Representatives and Senate in 1910, the seven-member commission appointed by Taft continued to include Olmsted. The Mall axis was extended according to the McMillan Plan beyond L'Enfant's original plan, and a canal-like reflecting basin was built between the Washington Monument and Henry Bacon's new Grecian-style temple housing the monumental statue of President Abraham Lincoln by Daniel Chester French in Potomac Park. This impressive memorial to the nation's sixteenth president, the subject of controversy like other elements of the plan, was not completed until 1922.

The McMillan plan had called for a national cemetery on the opposite bank of the Potomac with "white stones, inconspicuous in themselves, covering the gentle, wooded slopes, and producing the desired effect of a vast army in its last resting place."⁵ In 1925, Congress authorized construction of the Arlington Memorial Bridge according to designs prepared by the firm of McKim, Mead, and White. The bridge, a bridge plaza, and Water Gate between the bridge and the parkway proposed along the edge of Rock Creek were completed by 1932. Another important monument, one honoring the third president, Thomas Jefferson, was located at the end of the plan's great cross axis extending from Lafayette Square in front of the White House to a terminus in the Tidal Basin of the Potomac River. Plans inspired by the Pantheon in Rome were prepared for the Jefferson Memorial Commission by John Russell Pope, also the architect of the National Gallery of Art, and submitted shortly before his death in 1937. These were subjected to much wrangling, but after they had been somewhat modified, reduced in scale, and approved by the Senate in spite of objections from the Fine Arts Commission, the monument was put into construction in 1938. The

10.14. Plan for Chicago, Illinois, proposed by Daniel Burnham, 1909





10.16a and 10.16b. Senate Park Commission renderings of alternative closed and open valley plans for Rock Creek and Potomac Parkway, Washington, D.C. 1902

Below: 10.17. Plan for Rock Creek and Potomac Parkway, prepared by James G. Langdon, Office of Public Buildings and Grounds, 1916

McMillan Plan's proposal for a dignified treatment of the grounds immediately surrounding the Washington Monument, the linchpin of the entire National Capital redevelopment plan, was never carried out.

As with other elements of the plan, politics and professional rivalries plagued the development of Rock Creek and Potomac Parkway, a 2-and-1/2-mile (4-kilometer) scenic road connecting the Potomac waterfront near the Lincoln Memorial with Rock Creek Park north of the National Zoo at the northern boundary of the District of Columbia.⁶ It is sometimes forgotten that the City Beautiful movement, while advocating neoclassical monuments, axial planning, and geometrical landscape design, also propounded the need for park systems in which naturalistic landscaping complemented Beaux-Arts architectural grandeur. While Senator James McMillan chaired the Senate Committee on the District of Columbia, the official name of the 1901 McMillan Commission charged with detailing the plan for monumental Washington was the Senate Park Commission, and its 1902 report is titled *The Improvement of the Park System of the District of Columbia*. Frederick Law Olmsted, Jr., the author of the park and parkway sections of the report, sought to furnish the nation's capital with the same type of parks and park-connecting parkways that had recently been created in New York, Boston, and Buffalo and were

being developed for Cincinnati, Milwaukee, Minneapolis, and other American cities.

Seen as a means of curing an environmental problem and an eyesore (industrial wastes were dumped along the lower portions of Rock Creek), as well as a way to eliminate the topographical barrier between Georgetown and Washington proper, the project was delayed by debate, continuing for several years, over whether it should be an open-valley scenic parkway or a boulevard-type "closed" parkway covering a conduit (figs. 10.16a, 10.16b). Finally, on March 14, 1913, Congress passed a bill authorizing the open-valley concept. Olmsted continued to maintain his involvement as a consultant to the project and was disappointed when aspects of his advice, such as the perimeter roadways and some of the Picturesque effects seen in the 1916 plan, were ignored (fig. 10.17). Other aesthetically desirable elements were eliminated in the interests of economy and traffic engineering, but finally, in 1923, ten years after its authorization, the parkway was under construction. With the impetus gained from federal work programs in the 1930s, it was almost completed by the end of that decade.

The fulfillment of many of the objectives of the McMillan report remained the most realized achievement of the City Beautiful movement in America. Nowhere except in Washington, D.C., were the results of this effort accomplished on an urban scale, but several civic centers and many banks, libraries, museums, train stations, bridges, and monuments were added to the American cityscape as a result of this impulse (see fig. 9.59). Typically, municipal government followed, rather than led, the efforts that were organized by groups of public-spirited citizens and journalists as city after city in the United States followed the lead of Burnham and Robinson, seeking to counteract the ugliness of their earlier rapid commercial and industrial growth with Neoclassical urban monumentalism.

As we shall see in the next chapter, the rich vocabulary of forms inherited from France and Italy furnished British and American garden designers with many motifs, which they borrowed freely. The stu-

dents at the École des Beaux-Arts and the Rome Prize winners at the American Academy did not ponder deeply the humanist iconography informing these now agreeably mellow garden landscapes, but sought instead to appropriate their aura of venerability along with their undeniably fine compositional elements. They looked to these antique landscapes for inspiration because, like the characters in the novels of Henry James, they were subject to a peculiarly American sense of cultural inferiority. Regular transatlantic travel by steamship, another Industrial Age transportation advancement, made them acutely aware of their own country's narrow history and thin civilization when compared with the many centuries of human artistic endeavor recorded in the stones of Europe's ancient ruins, medieval cathedrals, and Renaissance villas and châteaux. Others of their coun-

trymen saw American civilization in somewhat different terms, as an opportunity to forge a new kind of national identity, one that celebrated the country's uniqueness in occupying almost an entire continent that was by nature endowed with scenery in all three traditional categories—beautiful, picturesque, and sublime. Surely, they reasoned with transcendentalist conviction, that very scenery, particularly in its sublime dimension, was a natural resource even more fundamental to the ethos of their freshly evolving civilization than any replication of European monumental grandeur on native soil could ever be. By conserving significant lands within the public domain through the creation of a national park system, they would vouchsafe for future generations this wonderful patrimony, which also constituted a newly available stimulus to tourism and recreation.

III. AMERICA THE BEAUTIFUL: THE NATIONAL PARK SYSTEM

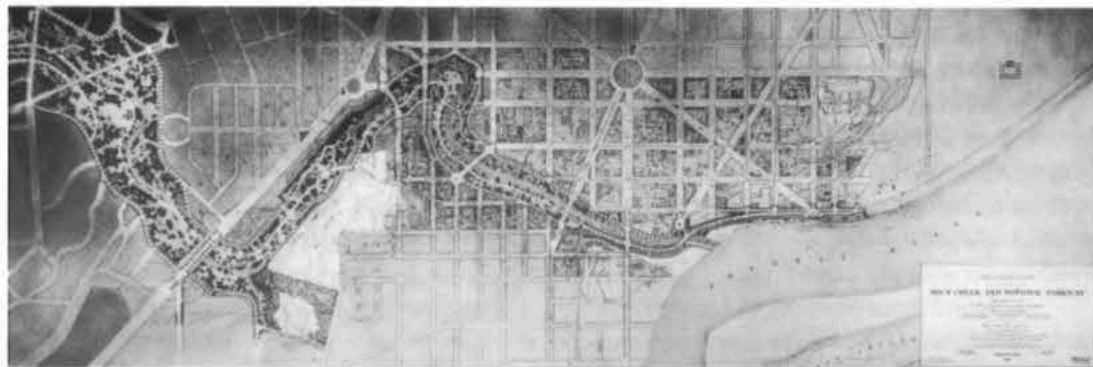
In 1851, a U.S. Army party known as the Mariposa Battalion pursued a band of Miwok-Paiute Indians into the Yosemite Valley of California. Although prospectors had come upon it earlier, it was the Mariposa Battalion's report of Yosemite's stunning scenery that aroused the interest of entrepreneurs eager to exploit natural wonders as tourist attractions. We may recall that journalists had played an important role in the creation of Central Park. Similarly, writers and publishers took up the Yosemite cause. In this they were aided by the emerging art of photography. Stereographs for the armchair traveler spread the fame of the sheer granite walls rising 3,000 feet (914 meters) from the valley floor, but the real power and majesty of the scenery was better conveyed by the prints made from large glass plate negatives by Carleton E. Watkins (1829–1916) and other photographers.

Wordsworthian Romanticism and the desire to celebrate an American equivalent to the Alps—which John Ruskin had brought into focus as scenery of the sublime category capable of inspiring emotion in cultivated breasts—as well as the delight American chauvinists found in appropriating a "sacred place" that was equivalent to a Gothic cathedral or a Greek temple soon led to the proposal to set aside the Yosemite and the nearby Mariposa Grove of giant sequoia trees (*Sequoia gigantea*) as an inalienable part of the public domain. A bill was introduced in the United States Senate in 1864 to cede these lands to the state of California "for public use, resort and recreation," and when it was passed and signed into law by President Abraham Lincoln, the first step had been taken toward preserving portions of the national scenic patrimony for popular enjoyment. At this time, envi-

ronmentalism and preserving wilderness to protect select ecosystems was not part of the public consciousness; the new park was regarded rather as a tourist commodity to be appreciated for its sublime scenery in the same manner as one would admire a noble work of art.

As discussed in Chapter Nine, at the time of Yosemite's acquisition by the state of California (it would later become part of the national park system), Frederick Law Olmsted, Sr., was in California as the director of the Mariposa Mines, and because of his reputation as a park administrator, was appointed by the governor to oversee the development of design and management policies for Yosemite Park and the Mariposa Big Tree Grove. In a letter to his wife, Olmsted shared his first impression of this fine stand of California giant sequoia trees: "You recognize them as soon as your eye falls on them, far away, not merely from the unusual size of the trunk but its remarkable color—a cinnamon color, very elegant. You feel that they are distinguished strangers [who] have come down to us from another world,—but the whole forest is wonderful."⁷

Olmsted, like almost everyone else at the time, realized the opportunity Yosemite presented for the burgeoning tourist industry and remarked in the report that he wrote in 1865 that Yosemite should "prove an attraction of similar character and a similar source of wealth to the whole community, not only of California but of the United States"⁸ as the natural scenery of Switzerland. The nineteenth-century appetite for scenic wonders was tremendous, as the popularity of Niagara Falls had proved. Here, on an even grander scale than Niagara, was an example



of scenery that could be characterized as sublime. Already painters and lithographers as well as photographers and writers were making a living depicting it, and hotel developers and souvenir vendors were busy with schemes to exploit it.

The first object of any plan for Yosemite would necessarily be to protect its scenic integrity and to prevent the kind of commercial exploitation that marred the landscape around Niagara in the nineteenth century. Fortunately nature had accomplished at Yosemite what extensive grading and planting had done in Central Park: the visual exclusion of the rest of the world from an idyllic landscape. Lofty walls enclosed the valley and helped the visitor experience the exhilarating sense of spatial completeness and sanctity as in a majestic cathedral. For Olmsted, Yosemite represented "the union of the deepest sublimity with the deepest beauty of nature, not in one feature or another, not in one part or one scene or another, not any landscape that can be framed by itself, but all around and wherever the visitor goes."⁹ It had taken him some months to appreciate the beauty of California's dry-climate vegetation, but now in his Yosemite report, he could rhapsodize: "Cliffs of awful height and rocks of vast magnitude . . . are banked and fringed and draped and shadowed by the tender foliage of noble and lovely trees and bushes, reflected from the most placid pools, and associated with the most tranquil meadows, the most playful streams, and every variety of soft and peaceful pastoral beauty."¹⁰ The plan that he proposed was one with as few "artificial constructions" as possible and a circular carriage drive with turnouts placed to present the best opportunities for scenic viewing.

Today we think of Yosemite as simply one park within a magnificent system of national parks, and

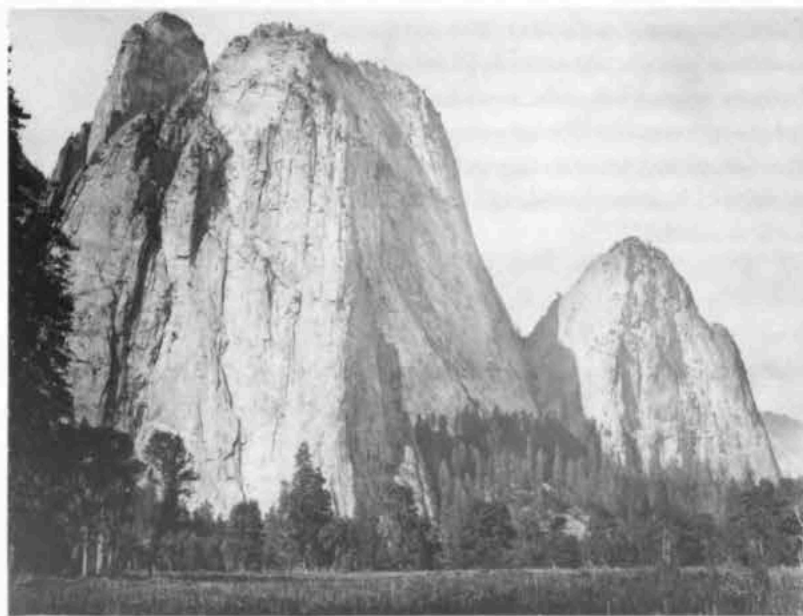
we therefore perhaps underestimate the powerful place it occupied in the nineteenth-century imagination. The geologist Clarence King must have felt, like Olmsted, that Yosemite presented a synthesis of the sublime and the beautiful when he spoke of "a soft aerial depth of purple tone . . . hiding details, veiling with its soft amethystine obscurity all that hard, broken roughness of the Sentinel cliffs."¹¹ The inclination toward the reverential was greatly enhanced by the atmospheric qualities of Albert Bierstadt's large and immensely popular paintings that cast religious light and color over the scene rather than emphasizing Yosemite's sculptural qualities as Carleton Watkins's photographs did (fig. 10.18).

Perhaps the Sierra Nevada and Yosemite found their true prophet in the naturalist John Muir (1838–1914). What Ruskin had been to the Alps, Muir was to the Sierra. Ruskin saw the mountains as the "schools and cathedrals" of the human race, "full of treasures of illuminated manuscript for the scholar, kindly in simple lessons to the worker, quiet in pale cloisters for the thinker, glorious in holiness for the worshipper."¹² Muir found holy inspiration in trying to fathom the geologic history of the mountains that had been shaped by almost unimaginably powerful forces, including the passage of mighty glaciers.

The poet Wordsworth, whose lasting influence pervaded, however unconsciously, the attitude of wilderness lovers such as Muir, had conceived of "spots in time," vivid scenes of nature that became imprinted on the mind. Like funds in the bank available for withdrawal at a later date, these scenes provided capital for recollection and contemplation in the future. Muir's impressions perhaps went further; he believed that the sights of nature reveal the majesty of God and leave a permanent mark upon our souls. To Ralph Waldo Emerson, he extended an invitation to experience the exaltation of a journey with him in the high Sierras. The transcendentalist and author of the famous essay "On Nature" answered the call and, in 1871, at the age of sixty-seven, made the arduous and rewarding journey.

Unknown except to Native Americans, trappers, and a few intrepid frontiersmen whose accounts of its seemingly fantastic, cosmically disordered scenery of spluttering mud volcanoes, shooting geysers, and boiling sulfur springs was often discounted, Yellowstone did not enter the public consciousness until around 1870. Again, it was journalists, artists, and photographers who stimulated appreciation of this collection of natural wonders. Ferdinand V. Hayden, director of the U.S. Geological Survey, sought funds for a scientific exploration of the area, and his expedition party included the photographer William H. Jackson (1843–1942) and the painter Thomas Moran

10.18. Carleton E. Watkins, *Cathedral Rock, 2,600 Feet, Yosemite*. c. 1866. The Metropolitan Museum of Art, New York. Elisha Whittelsey Collection



(1837–1926). Not only were the national parks to be objects of national pride and cultural icons themselves, but also the depiction of them set new standards of taste in landscape art and scenic appreciation. The work of Moran and Jackson was instrumental in the campaign that resulted in the passage in 1872 of a bill in Congress to establish Yellowstone as the country's first national park (fig. 10.19).

Proponents, many of whom were railroad magnates and businessmen, deemed the benefits of the proposed park to be considerable: It would stimulate tourism and passenger railroads. For many tourists, of course, it was not the sublimity of the Yellowstone Canyon that attracted them as much as the weird, infernal performances of the mud pots, hot springs, and geysers. They came primarily to be entertained by these phenomenal features. John Muir, however, could be depended on to read into the phantasmagorical Yellowstone landscape lessons both divine and Darwinian as he reminded his readers of the creative power of geologic forces embodying "creation, progress in the march of beauty through death."¹³ To his spiritual passion Muir wedded a practical sense, and through his efforts the Sierra Club was founded as an organization advocating public ownership of wilderness lands and, later, environmental protection in more general ways.

In 1890, the Yosemite area (minus the Yosemite Valley) was transferred from the state of California to the national government, and, in 1899, Mount Rainier

National Park was created. Other parks were acquired not only for scenic, but also for scientific and historical reasons, especially after Theodore Roosevelt, encouraged through his association with John Muir, became an early proponent of conservation. The administration of these parks was haphazard, for there was as yet no National Park Service. Then, in 1914, Stephen Mather (1867–1930), an industrialist in Chicago and an ardent hiker and member of the Sierra Club, wrote to Secretary of the Interior Franklin K. Lane, complaining of the condition of the parks. Lane, well aware of the problem, had already employed a young lawyer in California, Horace M. Albright, to study ways to improve the administration of the national parks. Recognizing that, as a businessman, Mather possessed considerable organizational and administrative talents, Lane promptly invited him to come to Washington, D.C., and take charge of the situation. Mather accepted the challenge, and he and Albright became a formidable team. Their combination of idealism and pragmatism forged the National Parks Act, creating the National Park Service, which President Woodrow Wilson signed into law in 1916. The national park system that was forged in the ensuing years—as many more national parks were created, historic sites designated, and large tracts of unspoiled coastline legislated into national seashores—is a proud achievement of the American people and has been a potent instrument in shaping the nation's image of itself.

10.19. Thomas Moran, *The Grand Canyon of the Yellowstone*. 1872. National Museum of American Art. Lent by the U. S. Department of the Interior, National Park Service

1. *Modernism* is the movement that responded optimistically to machine technology and the speeded-up tempo of twentieth-century machine-age civilization. It is expressed in several arts: in painting and sculpture as Cubism, Futurism, and other styles that fragment form and generally value its abstract character more than any remaining narrative content; in music as jazz, a fluid, improvisational medium that captures the syncopated tempo and erotic energy pulsing through urban life; in architecture as design that honors industrial technology and materials by divesting itself of the proportions and ornament of classical humanism and the structural means and decorative vocabulary inherited from the medieval and Renaissance past; in literature as poems and novels that portray the transactions between the human soul and societies in which the security of community has been superseded by personal anonymity and an intoxicating sense of possibility derived from new means of physical mobility and a new sense of social freedom. *Modernism* is fundamentally a state of culture that romanticizes reason, believing that rational application of science and technology combined with egalitarian politics will create a better world. *Postmodernism* questions modernism's attempted radical break with history and, because many modernist ideals have been discredited, sees its utopian articles of faith as naive. Being reactive, it is stylistically reiterative, re-presenting historical styles in quotation form, as echoes of earlier forms within a contemporary culture that is philosophically groundless and therefore without a special formal vocabulary of its own. Ironically, postmodern culture is vastly more machine-driven than the culture of modernism that preceded it.

2. During his visit to Paris in 1859, Olmsted noted the essential character of this aspect of French park construction, remarking that "The principal rock-work is much more like an operatic fairy scene than any thing in nature; and as its great size prevents it from being regarded as puerile or grotesque, like Chinese garden scenes, it may be considered to have been conceived in an original style to which the term romantic may be rightly applied." Essay on "Parks at Home and Abroad" (1861); see Charles Capen McLaughlin, ed.-in-chief, *The Papers of Frederick Law Olmsted, Volume III: Creating Central Park*, ed. Charles E. Beveridge and David Schuyler (Baltimore: The Johns Hopkins University Press, 1983), p. 349.

3. William Robinson, *The Parks, Promenades & Gardens of Paris* (London: John Murray, 1869), p. 64.

4. For a brilliant meditation upon the meaning of the Eiffel Tower, see Roland Barthes, *The Eiffel Tower and Other Mythologies*, trans. Richard Howard (New York: Farrar, Straus and Giroux, Inc., 1979). Here Barthes writes, "The Tower attracts meaning, the way a lightning rod attracts thunderbolts; for all lovers of signification, it plays a glamorous part, that of pure signifier, i.e., of a form in which men unceasingly put *meaning* (which they extract at will from their knowledge, their dreams, their history), without this meaning thereby ever being finite and fixed: who can say what the Tower will be for humanity tomorrow? But there can be no doubt it will always be something other and something much more than the Eiffel Tower" (University of California Press ed., 1997, p. 5).

5. Report of the Senate Committee on the District of Columbia on the Improvement of the Park System of the District of Columbia, *The Improvement of the Park System of the District of Columbia* (Washington: 1902) as quoted in John W. Reys, *Monumental Washington: The Planning and Development of the Capital Center* (Princeton: Princeton University Press), p. 131.

6. I am indebted to Timothy Davis, "Rock Creek and Potomac Parkway, Washington, DC: The Evolution of a contested urban landscape," *Studies in the History of Gardens & Designed Landscapes* 19:2 (April-June 1999) for the excellent research upon which the following narrative is drawn.

7. "Letter to Mary Perkins Olmsted, Bear Valley, November 20, 1863," in *The Papers of Frederick Law Olmsted, Volume V*, ed. Victoria Post Ranney (Baltimore: The Johns Hopkins University Press, 1990), pp. 136-37.

8. "Preliminary Report upon the Yosemite and Big Tree Grove," in *The Papers of Frederick Law Olmsted, Volume V*, ed. Victoria Post Ranney, p. 501.

9. *Ibid.*, p. 500.

10. *Ibid.*

11. John Muir, *Mountaineering in the Sierra Nevada*, as quoted in Sears, *Sacred Places: American Tourist Attractions in the Nineteenth Century* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1989), p. 134.

12. John Ruskin, *Modern Painters* (Boston: Dana Estes, 1880), vol. IV, p. 217.

13. "The Yellowstone National Park," *Our National Parks* (1901), as quoted in Sears, *op. cit.*, p. 177.